indeed a difficult task, was mainly done by Sukhdev'.[10] Thereafter it was Shastri who supplied Bhagat Singh with Vaillant's book, *Anarchism and Other Essays*, where 'one of its chapters was "Psychology of Violence" which contained the historic statement of the French anarchist . . . "It takes a loud voice to make the deaf hear." Having read the book, especially the statement of Vaillant, Bhagat Singh embraced me and said, "Dear Friend, you have given me an excellent piece of literature."'[11] Of course, as we now know, it was that statement which Bhagat Singh and B.K. Dutt used when they hurled their smoke bombs on the Delhi Assembly on 8 April 1929. But this was not all.

Bhagat Singh's voracious reading reshaped his mind. Yet, remarkably he is entirely unknown for it as far as the common man is concerned. He is known for his valour. He is not known for his immense learning. This is despite his comrades being fully aware of the influence of books on him. Shiv Verma memorably records how 'Bhagat Singh always moved with a small portable library. I don't remember even a single occasion when Bhagat Singh was not carrying some books. He had always two things with him – *Pistaul* ("pistol") and *Pustak* ("literary book"). I have seen him ill-clad and almost in rags, but even then he carried some book in his pocket'.[12] His mother, Smt. Vidyavati, in her 'Message to the Youth' on 1 November 1966 recalls how 'whenever Bhagat Singh came home, he always had his pocket full of books'. When she would 'pull him up for spoiling his pockets with these books', an unapologetic Bhagat Singh 'often explained with a smile that the books were about martyrs and patriots'.[13] In short, as Raja Ram Shastri explained, 'Bhagat Singh literally used to devour books' and 'his thirst for knowledge was ever unquenched'. There was, however, a method in his madness because 'he would read books, make notes, discuss with his friends and critically examine his own understanding in the light of new knowledge'.[14] At the end of this long road, such was the sea change in Bhagat Singh's intellectual reconstruction that he is himself seen to be describing this remodelling in 'Why I Am an Atheist' in the following terms: